SECTION 2 · STORY 2

WHAT THE BLOOD WAS FOR

The Havasupai Tribe and Arizona State University · Grand Canyon, USA · 1990–2010

The Havasupai are a Native American tribe of about 650 people, living deep in the Grand Canyon. From 1990, researchers from Arizona State University (ASU) collected blood from more than 200 members. Tribal leaders were told the study was about diabetes; the written consent form spoke more broadly, of “behavioral/medical disorders”.

The samples were used in 23 papers and dissertations. Fifteen had nothing to do with diabetes; they covered schizophrenia, inbreeding and the tribe’s origins. One suggested its ancestors came from Asia, while the tribe’s own history says they began in the canyon. Tribal council member Carletta Tilousi said: “people got degrees and grants, and they never asked our permission.”

The lead researcher defended the work as ethical: science often advances through studies not tied to one disease. In 2010, ASU’s governing board settled. It paid $700,000 to 41 tribe members, returned the samples and apologised. No court ever ruled on whether the research broke the law. The blood went home. The published papers did not.

They gave blood for a health study.
How much permission travelled with it?